CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Sunday, October 11, 2026

1,798 words · 7 min read

RE: Canberra fast-tracks drone shoot-down laws · Cocos Islanders denied COP31 seat · Burke demands migration costings · PNG-China trade expo slips to March 2027 · Rabuka urges unity on constitution

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,717	0.6988	13,749	0.5612
+0.40%	+0.52%	+0.50%	-0.09%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · China-Pacific · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Canberra is fast-tracking legislation to let Defence shoot down drones trespassing over military bases, with Australian firms scaling counter-drone technology to protect critical sites.
2. Port Moresby has pushed the inaugural PNG-China Business Forum and Trade Exposition back to March 2027, Trade and Investment Minister Richard Maru said.
3. Rabuka told Fijians the country must choose unity over division and dialogue over hostility as the constitutional reform argument hardens.

TOP STORIES

AU-DEFENSE

Canberra fast-tracks shoot-down powers against trespassing drones

The government is fast-tracking laws allowing the Department of Defence to shoot down drones that trespass over Australian military bases, the Australian Financial Review reported. Australian companies are simultaneously ramping up counter-drone technology aimed at protecting critical bases. The change would give Defence a legal basis to destroy uncrewed aircraft over its own estate, a power the current framework constrains.

per AFR: "Australia plans shoot-to-kill drone laws to counter rising threats"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Cocos Islanders denied COP31 seat as Canberra wraps Pacific pre-COP push

A delegation from the Cocos (Keeling) Islands, Australia's most isolated inhabited territory, will not attend COP31 in Türkiye after its application was approved by the United Nations but not selected by the federal government. The decision landed in the same week a contingent of federal ministers, including the prime minister, wrapped up pre-COP talks in Tuvalu and Fiji. The islands sit *8,900km* from this week's Pacific meetings and face the same coastal erosion and flooding. The University of Western Australia's Oceans Institute said it remains committed to working with the community.

per ABC News: "Albanese government's Pacific push leaves Cocos Island residents on the outer"

AU-POLITICS

Burke demands Coalition cost its migration plan: "we are talking billions"

Burke demanded the Coalition publish costings for its deportation and migration plan, saying "we are talking billions," as the government opened a fresh line of attack on **Angus Taylor**'s policy. Burke would not say whether Labor had made mistakes of its own on migration management. Taylor conceded on Sunday that the Coalition could not fully cost the policy, pointing to limits within the Parliamentary Budget Office, and said more detail would come closer to the election.

per SMH Federal Politics: "'We are talking billions': Burke demands costings on Coalition deportation plan" · also ABC Politics

OVERNIGHT

AU-DEFENSE

Canberra marks 25 years since Australian forces deployed to Afghanistan · ABC News

Anthony Albanese, Governor-General **Sam Mostyn**, former prime minister **John Howard** and Taylor attended a wreath-laying at the Australian War Memorial marking twenty-five years since Australian forces deployed under Operation Slipper. More than 35,000 Australians served in Afghanistan or in supporting Middle East roles; forty-seven ADF personnel died and 263 were wounded. **Ben Roberts-Smith**, who faces five counts of war crime murder, was granted court permission to travel to Canberra for the service.

AU-DEFENSE

Garrett calls defence land sell-off "laziness" and "poor politics" · The Australian

Former Labor minister **Peter Garrett** became the latest figure to attack the government's plan to sell defence sites, describing it as "laziness" and "poor politics," The Australian reported. The intervention follows **Cosgrove**'s warning earlier this week against a "shallow" sale of Victoria Barracks, widening an argument inside Labor's own ranks over disposing of Defence estate.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Gas producers warn of market paralysis as reservation scheme lands this week · The Australian

Labor's domestic gas reservation scheme is due to be finalised this week, and producers fear the announcement will freeze the market for a prolonged period, The Australian reported. The scheme follows the government's commitment to keep more LNG output at home. Export contracts and new supply decisions hinge on the detail of what volumes must be withheld for the domestic market.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Global Day for Gaza rallies renew pressure over arms trade with Israel · ABC News

Protesters gathered in capital cities and regional centres for the Global Day for Gaza, three years after the October 7 Hamas attack, demanding sanctions and an end to Australia's arms trade with Israel. Thousands massed at Sydney's Hyde Park before marching through the central business district. The Department of Defence said in a statement in August last year that Australia has not supplied weapons or ammunition to Israel since the conflict began.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Tanker captains offered $US100,000 a month to run the Strait of Hormuz · ABC News

Oil tanker captains in the Persian Gulf are being paid up to $US100,000 a month, about $143,000, to transit the Strait of Hormuz while Iran and the United States maintain separate blockades, industry insiders and maritime unions told the ABC. Facebook advertisements seen by the ABC show seafarers in Asia offered double or triple pay plus danger money. Brent crude settled at 104.72, up 4.12 percent, on October 9.

STAT OF THE DAY

47

ADF personnel killed in Afghanistan service

Canberra marked 25 years since Operation Slipper began, with more than 35,000 Australians having served and 263 wounded.

ABC News

PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · FIJIVILLAGE

Rabuka urges unity as constitutional reform argument hardens

Rabuka said Fiji must choose "unity over division, dialogue over hostility," and that constitutional discussions must strengthen democracy rather than divide the nation. The appeal follows a teachers' union leader's threat earlier this week that inflamed the reform debate.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji's health minister warns rising seas threaten health facilities

Fiji's health minister warned that rising sea levels are threatening the country's health facilities, Fiji Sun reported. The warning lands in the week Fiji hosted pre-COP31 events and as Pacific governments press donors on adaptation financing for coastal infrastructure.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Blue Prosperity adviser puts customary owners at centre of ocean policy

Blue Prosperity Fiji strategic adviser **Joeli Veitayaki**, of the University of the South Pacific's School of Marine Studies, told the Pre-COP31 Investing in Natural Capital event at Nadi that marine expeditions proceed only with community permission and recognise iTaukei qoliqoli fishing grounds. "Economic growth can coexist with a healthy environment," he said.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG elections committee discloses Canberra consultation with new commissioner

The Special Parliamentary Committee on the 2027 National Elections, chaired by **Allan Bird**, disclosed that it consulted **Professor Dr Nicole Haley** in Canberra as an expert while drafting its report, and said it has held no

private meetings with her since her appointment as Electoral Commissioner. The disclosure answers questions about the committee's relationship with the commission ahead of the 2027 poll.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Maru says PNG must expand generation to use the Ramu Grid highway

Richard Maru, the minister responsible for PNG Power Limited, said the country must focus on expanding generation capacity to fully use the electricity transmission highway built for the Ramu Grid. Transmission capacity outstripping generation has left parts of the grid underused.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Post-Courier price tracker finds wide retail gaps across Port Moresby

The Post-Courier launched a weekly Retail Price Tracker showing major differences in the price of rice, tinned fish and Ox and Palm depending on where shoppers buy in Port Moresby. The series puts published figures behind a cost-of-living debate that has run without comparable retail data.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · NZ HERALD

Peters campaigns in Dunedin as Herald fact-checks the NZ First pitch

Foreign Minister **Winston Peters** took the NZ First campaign to Dunedin, with the New Zealand Herald separating fact from fiction in his claims. Peters leads the coalition's smallest partner into the November 7 vote after a week in which he reopened conversion therapy and abortion and was shut down by **Christopher Luxon**.

NZ-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

New Zealand election race intensifies ahead of November 7 vote

The Australian reported the New Zealand campaign tightening with under four weeks to polling day. Advance voting opens on October 26 for the November 7 election, the first test of the National, ACT and NZ First coalition formed in 2023.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Luxon takes RNZ campaign interview series through Howick

Luxon joined RNZ's Power Steering series, recorded in his childhood suburb of Howick, in the fifth instalment of leader interviews that has also featured **David Seymour**, **Chloe Swarbrick**, **Chris Hipkins** and The Opportunity Party's **Qiulae Wong**. The sequence maps the five leaders now contesting the November vote.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · TRADE AND INVESTMENT · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG pushes inaugural China business forum and trade expo to March 2027

Minister for International Trade and Investment **Richard Maru** said the inaugural PNG-China Business Forum and Trade Exposition has been moved to March next year. The delay comes after China and Papua New Guinea marked 50 years of diplomatic relations in Beijing on September 30.

REGIONAL · STATE MEDIA MESSAGING · CHINA DAILY (REGION) STATE MEDIA

China Daily says Pacific Island countries seek lasting gains from China ties

China Daily published a regional piece arguing Pacific Island countries are pursuing durable benefits from their relationships with Beijing. It follows the paper's item last week drawing Pacific "lessons" from the Long March legacy and a Chinese official's line that Beijing never treats island nations as an arena for major-power rivalry.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · GUARDIAN AU POLITICS

Hanson says Liberal cooperation is "up to Angus Taylor" after CPAC reception

Pauline Hanson told the Conservative Political Action Conference in Brisbane that cooperation between One Nation and the Liberals is "up to Angus Taylor," putting preference arrangements at the centre of the right's next move. Guardian Australia's Josh Butler wrote that the reception for the three conservative leaders left Hanson as the effective preferred opposition leader, with Taylor received as the head of a minor party.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Polling finds One Nation support softening, with Albanese wearing cost-of-living blame

Support for One Nation and Hanson is softening, according to polling reported by the Sydney Morning Herald, while voters blame the government rather than the Reserve Bank for cost-of-living pressure. The finding cuts against the premise of the weekend's conservative conference, where both Coalition and One Nation leaders pitched to the same voters.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Taylor says he would welcome Frydenberg's return to the Liberals

Taylor said he would welcome **Josh Frydenberg** back if the former treasurer contests a seat at the next election, saying he needed "every good leader." Frydenberg released excerpts of his memoir A Grateful Son in The Australian on Saturday, urging the Liberal Party to reclaim the political centre and proposing changes on energy, artificial intelligence and linking a share of state GST revenue to housing construction.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Hanson dismisses Wilson's Liberal leadership prospects

Hanson said Wilson was "full of himself" if he believed he was fit for the Liberal leadership, The Australian reported. The remark, delivered while Taylor's own standing on the right is being tested, feeds speculation about the Liberal leadership eight months after Taylor won the February spill.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Burke flags rise in "weirdly mixed" violent ideologies

Burke described a rise in "logically inconsistent" and "weirdly mixed" ideologies centred on violence, The Australian reported. The assessment follows the Australian Federal Police commissioner's warning this week about hostile governments using local actors inside Australia.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Auction clearance rate stays below 50 percent for a second week

Australia's home auction clearance rate remained below 50 percent for a second consecutive week, Bloomberg reported. The housing market is absorbing a cash rate held at 4.35 percent on August 11 after three increases earlier in 2026.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Firmus chief calls collapsed float a "great loss for Australia"

Oliver Curtis described the failure of the Firmus ASX listing as a "great loss for Australia," The Australian reported, after the data centre group abandoned a float earlier valued at $5 billion. The company's withdrawal removed what would have been one of the year's largest local technology listings.

UPCOMING

OCT 13

Fiji schools reopen after the Fiji Day public holiday

Education Minister Aseri Radrodro confirmed classes resume Tuesday after confusion over closures.

OCT 26

Advance voting opens in the New Zealand general election

Early ballots lock in a large share of the vote before the final fortnight of campaigning.

OCT 2026

Labor's domestic gas reservation scheme to be finalised

Sets the volumes LNG exporters must hold back for the domestic market and conditions new supply decisions.

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Decides whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues, and with it Wellington's foreign and defence settings.

MAR 2027

Inaugural PNG-China Business Forum and Trade Exposition

Rescheduled by Minister Richard Maru, it will be the first dedicated PNG-China commercial showcase since the 50-year anniversary of ties.

THE WIRE

AU-POLITICS

SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Former Liberal premier calls the migration policy economically weak

A former Liberal premier wrote in the Sydney Morning Herald that the party's migration move is economically weak and socially irresponsible, warning that blaming migration for a range of problems invites darker propositions about the causes of national problems.

SMH WORLD

Badenoch's fight with Reform held up as a lesson for Taylor

The Sydney Morning Herald argued that U.K. Conservative leader **Kemi Badenoch**'s combative response to Reform offers a template for Taylor, who is managing the same squeeze from One Nation on the Australian right.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

FIJI SUN

Suva court acquits former RFMF finance officer over $182,000 in supply deals

Resident Magistrate **Vinaina Diroiroi** acquitted former Republic of the Fiji Military Forces finance officer **Sarika Devi Raj** on two counts of abuse of office. The Fiji Independent Commission Against Corruption alleged she failed to declare ownership of Maleka Kava and Maleka Investment, which received $152,320 and $30,084.99 from the RFMF between 2019 and 2020.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

ABC NEWS

Canberra tells travellers not to fly to Riyadh after three airport attacks

The Australian government advised travellers against flying to Riyadh after three attacks on Saudi airports this week killed 12 people and wounded more than 300. Operations at King Khalid International Airport are suspended, with hundreds of flights cancelled, after Houthi missile and drone strikes.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

Read online · Past issues

You are receiving the Australia Daily Brief as a member of the CSIS Australia Chair distribution list.

This newsletter is automatically generated, so it may contain errors. Please check all information and sources before citing. To report errors or other issues, please contact Andy Lim at alim@csis.org.

generated 6:12 AM ET

↑ BACK TO TOP

© 2026 Center for Strategic and International Studies